

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS: COLD OPEN

VO.4

2026-08-31. Provenance: ChatGPT's rewrite of Fable's vo.3, guided by GPT's research into common true-crime podcast voice and prose, brought by Stephen and adopted with one fix. This is the live open; vo.3 is superseded.

Stephen's rulings on adoption:

1. **Length is acceptable.** The open is spread over multiple leads in the FTUE, so the real cost is about one more lead requirement in the tutorial, not a lost installer at a single cliff. Refine the length later only where it costs nothing.
2. **"Knew who had wanted her dead" overstated the letter** (it said she knew; it named nobody) and is fixed: "This one didn't say she thought. It said she knew."
3. **The mirrored pair ("I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her.") is retired.** Trish, in writing: "Why doesn't she just say that they were frightened of each other?" Plain over crafted.
4. **The consent-on-microphone line is removed as obvious and redundant.** The practice itself stays canon (bible §2.3.1); it is simply not narrated.

Voice lesson banked (Trish + Stephen, this review): Ally's register is the common true-crime podcast voice: short lines, one fact per line, plain statements over crafted constructions, no term-of-art phrasing, never state the obvious. Applies to all future Ally prose.

Checks: no em dashes (pass) · nothing invented beyond the brief (pass; "one of them could be next" is the survivors' real fear, kept) · death in the first line, keys by about 0:35 (pass) · sign-off as ruled.

This is Echoes of Havenbay. I'm Ally Quinn.

Nine months ago, a forty-four-year-old woman named Violet Moore was found dead at the bottom of her stairs.

Violet painted signs for a living. If you walked around this city, you'd see her work everywhere. Above shops. On boats. She even painted the side of a bus once.

Her death was ruled an accident. A terrible fall causing blunt force trauma to her head, nothing more.

But two weeks later, four people received something in the post.

Each of them got an identical key and a letter written in Violet's handwriting.

Their names were Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera and Brad Collins. They were Violet's closest friends. And according to the letter, one of them may have been planning to kill her.

Violet didn't know which one. She admitted she might be wrong. But she was frightened enough to leave behind four keys.

She also told her friends not to go to the police.

Instead, she directed them to a locked door. Behind it, she said, was the reason she had become afraid.

The four friends called each other that night. They agreed that nobody would open the door alone. They'd wait until Saturday, when all four of them could be there together.

And when they finally opened it, they found another letter.

This one didn't say she thought. It said she knew.

There was an object beside it. Something that had belonged to Violet. Two of the friends are still alive, and neither one will say what that object was.

Then the group began to disappear.

Seven weeks after Violet's funeral, Brad drove to Kestrel Head, a place known for people who don't plan on coming home. His car was found there, but Brad never was.

Five months later, Margo's car appeared in the same car park. Three days after that, her body washed into the harbour.

That left Liam and Ruby.

They both went to the police. Separately. And each of them said the same basic thing.

I'm afraid of the other one.

Police examined Violet's letters and found no reason to believe they were fake. They looked into Liam. They looked into Ruby. They found nothing they could use.

Now Liam and Ruby are accusing each other publicly, and Violet's warning is tearing them apart as Havenbay takes sides.

Ruby has agreed to speak with me. Liam hasn't. At least, not yet.

I don't know what was behind that locked door. I don't know whether Violet really identified her killer. And I don't know whether Liam or Ruby has a reason to be afraid.

But four friends received four keys.

Nine months later, two of them are dead, and the other two believe one of them could be next.

So that's where we begin.

With Violet, her four friends and the door she wanted them to open.

This is Echoes of Havenbay, I'm Ally Quinn. Goodnight for now, Harbour. Sleep tight.